THE GREAT AI PUZZLE

AI

is a term that seems to be on everyone's radar but also one of the biggest mysteries in public discourse. We have all been users of AI both knowingly and unknowingly—whether taking the fastest route using Google Search or Netflix throwing up movies that you may like to see based on your recent viewing. But major developments have happened in the past four years caused by a groundbreaking class of AI algorithms—called Generative AI—which are now reading and interpreting text in the ways human intelligence would. It's a technological apparition that is expected to alter almost every aspect of life as we know it: from work and employment to the global economy, from electoral politics to justice, from defence technology to policing and surveillance, from the arts and entertainment to our most intimate and private information. Both dream and nightmare, fantasy and inevitability, the technological chimera we have apparently whelped has been greeted with as much anxiety as excitement. Will AI replicate and replace us as emotional companions? Will it compromise our privacy and our bearing on truth and reality? Is it an unstoppable engine, plagiarising human creativity? The apprehension that this transformative technology seems to be on the threshold of an exponential change—'the singularity' of self-amplifying Artificial General Intelligence—and that this is happening at a time of significant global crises, including major armed conflict, political polarisation in democracies, a realigning world order, massive movements of migrants and, of course, global warming and climate change—has only sharpened public interest in its potential to dramatically improve or damage our lives. For India, AI now offers the promise of leapfrogging technology as we did with the telecom revolution—from plain old telephony to rapid adoption of smart phones—and harnessing its potential to quicken the pace of our quest to be a developed nation. To unravel the hope from the paranoia and the reality from the fiction, we invited a spectrum of prominent stakeholders, both Indian and global—heads of information technology mega-corporations, policymakers, scientists, social scientists, artists and entertainers—to consider how AI could change our lives. Their opinions, as you will see, are reassuringly, and very humanly, varied, ranging from enthusiasm to despair, but there is also a consensus that AI (whatever it is) is coming and that while we should exploit the immense potential it holds, it must be deployed with caution and attention. Read on. ■

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